THE PURPOSEFULLY EATING EBOOK SERIES · 02

Eating Through *Emotions*

A compassionate guide to what's really happening when food feels bigger than food.

Phyllis Inman

A NOTE FROM PHYLLIS

This book is not *against* emotional eating.

Most books on this subject are. They treat it as a bug in your wiring — a behavior to stop, a habit to break, a willpower gap to close. The language is military: conquer, defeat, beat. As if the part of you that reaches for food when you're sad or tired or overwhelmed is a kind of enemy.

I don't believe that. I never have.

Emotional eating is not the enemy. It is a signal. It is one of the oldest, most reliable ways human beings have always self-soothed. The part of you that opened the pantry after a hard phone call — that part is not broken. That part is trying to help.

What I'll teach you in this book is not how to stop that part. I'll teach you how to meet it. How to hear what it's trying to tell you. And how, over time, to build a wider menu of responses — so that food becomes one tool among many, instead of the only tool on your workbench.

> *You do not need to defeat your emotional eating. You need to understand it. The rest — the softening, the slowing, the expanding — follows.*

This is a gentle book. It is also a useful one. By the end, you'll have a 5-tool kit for the moments when food feels like the only option, a framework for reading your own patterns, and — most importantly — a new relationship with the version of you who eats when she's not hungry.

She has always been trying to take care of you. Let's finally let her.

With you,

Phyllis

BEFORE WE BEGIN

A *clinical* note.

This book is educational. It is not clinical care.

If you are currently experiencing symptoms of a clinical eating disorder — binge eating disorder, bulimia, anorexia, ARFID, or disordered patterns significant enough to affect your health — please work with a qualified clinician. This book is a supplement to, never a replacement for, that care.

Resources at the end of this book include the National Eating Disorders Association (NEDA) and how to find a non-diet registered dietitian or therapist specializing in disordered eating. Please use them if you need them.

If you are generally well and the pattern that brought you here is the very common one of eating when you're stressed, sad, lonely, bored, or overwhelmed — then this book is for you. Let's begin.

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I

PART ONE

The Truth About *Emotional Eating.*

Before any tools, any practices, any fixes — four things worth understanding about what emotional eating actually is, and why the war you've been waging against it has been the wrong war.

CHAPTER 1

Emotional eating is *not the enemy.*

A reframe you may need to read several times before it lands. That's fine. Keep reading.

Here is what emotional eating actually is: one of the oldest, most reliable ways human beings have known how to self-soothe.

Long before we had therapists, or meditation apps, or spin classes, or Xanax, or Instagram, we had food. Food was how we gathered. How we mourned. How we celebrated. How we welcomed. How we apologized. How we said *I love you* to a sick friend and *thank you* to a neighbor and *you matter to me* to a child.

Food was never only fuel. That is a modern, Puritan, calorie-counting fiction. Food has, for the entirety of human history, also been *comfort*. And there is nothing pathological about that. Not yesterday, not today, not tomorrow.

> *The part of you that eats when you're tired, sad, or overwhelmed is not broken. It is ancient. It is trying, in the way it knows how, to take care of you.*

So what's the problem, then?

The problem is not that you sometimes eat for reasons that aren't hunger. That is normal, human, and often fine. The problem — if there is one — is that food has become the *only* tool in your toolbox.

When food is one of many ways you meet your emotional needs — alongside rest, connection, movement, creative expression, touch, tears, conversation, nature — it plays its rightful role. You eat a bowl of ice cream after a hard day, enjoy it, and move on.

When food is the *only* way you meet your emotional needs, it starts to stagger under that weight. It can't. No single tool was meant to do every job. The ice cream that was never the problem becomes the only companion on a lonely Tuesday, the only celebration on a good Thursday, the only numbing agent on a hard Friday. That is when the pattern stops serving you.

The shift this book is built on

We are not going to try to stop the emotional eating. We are going to try to expand the toolbox.

We are going to build your awareness, so you can see the pattern with curiosity instead of shame. We are going to hand you five new tools, so food doesn't have to carry every emotional need by itself. And over time — slowly, without force — you'll find the reach for food becomes one option among several, not the only one.

What I am *not* saying

Three things I want to make clear, so nobody reads this and feels I've waved away a real problem:

One: If food is actively harming you — if you're in a binge-purge cycle, if eating is disrupting your ability to function, if it's causing genuine distress or medical risk — that is not what this book is for. Please get clinical support. A non-diet registered dietitian, a therapist specializing in eating disorders, a treatment program if needed. The reframe I've just offered is for people with *problematic* but not *clinical* patterns. The distinction matters.

Two: Permission is not a free-for-all. Saying "emotional eating is not the enemy" is not the same as saying "eat anything, any time, and never think about it." The method in this book is built on awareness, not abandonment. You will absolutely still be thinking about it. Just differently.

Three: This work is slow. There is no 30-day fix. What you'll learn here will likely take a year to feel natural. Five years to integrate. That is a feature, not a bug. We are rewiring a lifelong pattern. That does not happen in a weekend.

TAKE WITH YOU

Your emotional eating is trying to help you. We are not going to stop it. We are going to **expand your toolkit** so it has company. Over time, it will quiet. Not through force. Through not needing to carry everything alone.

CHAPTER 2

The *five flavors* of emotional eating.

Not all emotional eating is the same. Identifying which flavor is visiting you changes everything about how you meet it.

In my work with clients, I've noticed that "emotional eating" as a category is too broad to be useful. When someone says "I'm an emotional eater," I've learned to ask a second question: *which flavor?* The answer changes the entire response.

There are five flavors I see over and over. You will recognize yourself in some of them. You may be familiar with several. Almost nobody is only one.

Flavor 1 · Stress eating

The big one. Your nervous system is flooded with cortisol, you're in a state of mild-to-major fight-or-flight, and your body — sensibly — reaches for quick, dense energy. Sugar. Crunchy things. Carb-heavy comfort. This is not a character flaw. It is a body doing exactly what it was built to do under stress.

Often looks like: afternoon snack binges after hard meetings, midnight freezer raids after fights, a handful of chocolate in the pantry after a boundary-violating phone call.

Flavor 2 · Sadness eating

Grief, loneliness, loss, disappointment. Sadness eating tends to be slower, softer, and more solitary than stress eating. It seeks *warmth* and *company* — foods that feel like a hug. Creamy pasta. Hot soup. Mashed potatoes. Ice cream that tastes like childhood.

Often looks like: eating alone after a breakup, reaching for childhood foods when you're missing someone, warm comfort food on a cold emotional day.

Flavor 3 · Boredom eating

Understimulation, restlessness, a dulled inner life. You're not hungry, not sad, not stressed — you're *bored*. And food gives your hands and your mouth and your brain something to do. This one is often mindless, almost automatic — a graze-y, steady pull through the pantry.

Often looks like: grazing while working from home, chips during a dull movie, the 3pm "what's there to eat?" lap of the kitchen.

Flavor 4 · Celebration eating

The friendliest flavor — and the one that rarely needs fixing. This is eating tied to joy, connection, ritual

Flavor 5 · Numbing eating

The heaviest flavor. Not stress exactly, not sadness exactly — a feeling of *too muchness*. Overwhelm, suppressed anger, low-grade despair, disconnection. Numbing eating seeks to make something stop. To dial down the volume of whatever is happening inside.

It often has a disassociative quality — you're not quite present for it. Twenty minutes can pass without you tasting anything. When it ends, there's often a wave of shame.

Often looks like: eating in front of the TV until you feel nothing, late-night eating that isn't about hunger, eating on autopilot during periods of emotional exhaustion.

This is the flavor most worth understanding. It is also the one that benefits most from the 5-tool kit in Part Three — and, sometimes, from professional support.

Why the flavors matter

Because the response to each flavor is different. Stress eating responds to nervous-system regulation — breath, walking, a cold glass of water. Sadness eating needs connection — a call to a friend, a bath, a good cry. Boredom eating needs stimulation — movement, a creative project, a walk outside. Celebration eating needs absolutely nothing — enjoy it. Numbing eating needs compassion, self-understanding, and often the slowest, gentlest approach of all.

A PRACTICE FOR THIS WEEK

The next time you find yourself reaching for food when you're not hungry, ask one question — without judgment, without changing anything: *which flavor is this?* Just name it. That's the whole practice for now. Naming is the beginning.

In Part Two, we'll build the awareness layer that lets you catch the flavor before the reach. In Part Three, we'll build the five specific tools. For now, just start noticing.

> *Not all emotional eating is the same thing. Name the flavor. That is the first tool.*

CHAPTER 3

Why "just use willpower" *doesn't work.*

A short chapter on why you are not a weak-willed person — and why every book that promised willpower would fix this was lying to you.

Willpower-based approaches to emotional eating rest on a simple premise: there is a wrong behavior (eating when not hungry), and a right response (not doing that), and the bridge between them is *self-control*. If you have enough of it, you win. If you don't, you lose.

This premise is wrong in three specific ways. I'll name them — because once you see them, a lot of the self-blame you've been carrying will be harder to carry.

First: willpower is a finite resource

Psychologists call it "ego depletion." Your capacity to exert self-control is not infinite. It is drained by every decision, interaction, and effortful task you perform in a day. By the time you reach 8pm — after work, kids, traffic, dinner, dishes — your willpower tank is usually nearly empty. That is when most emotional eating happens. Not because you are "weak at night." Because you've been using your willpower all day, and there is none left.

Telling a person with an empty willpower tank to "use more willpower" is like telling a person with an empty gas tank to "drive harder."

Second: willpower fights the symptom, not the cause

If emotional eating is an attempt to regulate an emotion, then using willpower to stop the eating does not address the emotion. The stress, sadness, boredom, or overwhelm is still there. It's just not being met with food anymore.

In the short term, this looks like success. In the long term, the suppressed emotion finds another outlet — or it comes back, louder, and breaks through willpower entirely. This is why "diets fail." It is not because the dieter was weak. It is because the dieter never actually addressed what was driving the eating. The eating was the smoke. The fire was still burning.

Third: willpower relies on self-punishment

Every willpower-based approach is, at its core, adversarial. You versus yourself. The good part versus the bad part. And when the bad part wins — which it will, because finite resources — the good part punishes the bad part. With shame, with restriction, with a new rule.

This self-punishment does not produce change. It produces *more of the same behavior*. Shame activates

What works instead

If willpower is the wrong tool, what's the right one?

Awareness. Curiosity. Self-compassion. A wider toolkit. Patience with yourself across years, not weeks. Noticing without judging. Responding without punishing. Expanding the range of ways you meet your needs — with food still on the list, just no longer alone.

These sound soft. They are not. They are slower, harder, and more psychologically demanding than sheer self-denial — because they ask you to feel what you've been numbing. That is the real work. That is also the work that lasts.

A PERMISSION SLIP

If you've been trying to "just use willpower" for years and failing — please know you were not failing at a reasonable task. You were failing at an impossible one. Put it down. We're going to build something else.

CHAPTER 4

The neuroscience, *in plain English.*

What your brain is actually doing when you reach for food. No jargon. No fancy brain-diagram. Just the parts worth knowing.

You don't need a neuroscience degree to work with your emotional eating. But knowing a few things about what's happening in your brain and body — the actual, physical story — will help you stop blaming yourself.

Here are the four things worth knowing.

One · Food activates reward circuits

When you eat — especially foods high in sugar, fat, or salt — your brain releases dopamine. Dopamine is the neurotransmitter of *pleasure anticipation* and *reward*. It feels good. It is supposed to feel good. This is how our species survived — we were rewarded for eating calorie-dense foods because they were scarce and we needed them.

In modern life, that reward system still runs on old software. The food is no longer scarce, but your brain doesn't know that. It still hands out dopamine every time you eat something sweet, rich, or crunchy. That is not "addiction" — it is normal human biology. It is why that bite of ice cream after a hard day feels like relief. It is, at the chemical level, relief.

Two · Stress raises cortisol, which raises appetite

When you're under stress, your adrenal glands release cortisol. Cortisol has many jobs, but one of them is: *mobilize quick energy.* In ancestral terms, you were about to fight a predator or flee one, and you needed fuel fast.

Today, the predator is usually an email or an in-law. But the cortisol response is the same. Your body gets ready for a physical effort that never comes. And a cortisol-elevated body craves quick-energy food. Sweet. Dense. Easy.

This is not a failure of discipline. This is your endocrine system doing exactly what it was designed to do. Blaming yourself for craving sugar during a stressful week is like blaming yourself for sweating when you're hot.

Three · Emotion and eating share neural real estate

The insula, the amygdala, and the hypothalamus — three brain regions involved in emotional processing — also play a role in regulating hunger and fullness. This is not an accident. In the human brain, emotion

Four · The nervous system runs the show

Most emotional eating happens when your nervous system is dysregulated — either in fight-or-flight (sympathetic) or in collapse/freeze (dorsal vagal). In either state, your executive brain (prefrontal cortex, the part that does logic and long-term thinking) goes offline. You are not "choosing" to eat in those moments, not really. The older, faster parts of your brain are choosing.

This is why willpower often fails at the moment of the eating. The part of you that would use willpower is not in the room.

The solution? Not more willpower. Nervous system regulation. Breath work. Cold water on your face. A short walk. Anything that signals to your nervous system that you are safe, slows the cortisol, and brings your executive brain back online. *Then* you can make a real decision.

> *You cannot think your way out of a dysregulated nervous system. You have to regulate it first. Then thinking becomes possible again.*

Why this matters

The takeaway of this chapter is not complicated: *you are not broken*. The mechanisms that produce emotional eating are the same mechanisms that kept your ancestors alive. They are functioning correctly. The issue is that they are running on ancient software in a modern world that is very different from the world they were designed for.

The work ahead is not to override your biology. It is to work with it.

That's Part One. The truth.
Now — the awareness.

II

PART TWO

The Awareness *Layer.*

Five short chapters that teach you how to see the pattern before you live the pattern. Without awareness, no tool works. With awareness, most tools become optional.

CHAPTER 5

The *pre-eating pause.*

A 30-second practice that does more than most 30-day programs.

Before we build tools, we build awareness. And before we build awareness, we create a gap. A space. A moment between the urge and the action.

Most emotional eating is automatic. The urge arises, the hand reaches, the eating happens. Often you don't even remember deciding. The whole sequence takes maybe seven seconds, and by the time your conscious mind catches up, you're three bites in.

The pre-eating pause interrupts the automatic part. That's it. That's the whole job. It doesn't ask you to not eat. It doesn't ask you to "choose better." It just asks you, briefly, to be present.

The practice

THE PRE-EATING PAUSE · 30 SECONDS

Before eating — any eating, meal or not — take **three slow breaths**. Hand on chest if it helps. Eyes open or closed.

Then ask yourself, silently: *"What is this for?"*

Don't answer out loud. Don't change your decision based on the answer. Just ask. Then eat, or don't. Both are fine.

That's the whole practice. Three breaths. One question. No decision required.

Why it works

Those three breaths are doing more than you think. They are signaling to your nervous system that there is time — that you are not, at this moment, being chased by a predator. That signal allows the prefrontal cortex — the rational, present part of your brain — to come back online. Which means: whatever you do next, you're doing with your whole self.

And the question — *"What is this for?"* — is not asking you to justify or deny the eating. It is asking you to notice what's happening. That alone shifts everything.

Some of the answers you'll get, with practice:

- *"I'm hungry."* Great. Eat.
- *"I'm stressed."* Okay. Now you know. Maybe you still eat. Maybe you pause longer.
- *"I'm bored."* Noted. Sometimes you still eat. Sometimes something else sounds better.

The expected pushback

Many of my clients, when they first try this, say some version of: *"I know I'm eating for emotional reasons. I don't need to pause. I just want to stop."*

I hear them. And still — I ask them to do the pause.

Because the thing they think they know — "I know I'm eating for emotional reasons" — is usually a story told from shame. It isn't actual awareness. Actual awareness, in the moment, is a different animal. It is curious. It is not-judging. It is genuinely open to what the answer turns out to be.

The pause builds that kind of awareness. Story-level knowing doesn't.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT THIS WEEK

Practice the pre-eating pause for the next seven days. Before every eating event — meals, snacks, the 3pm handful of almonds, the 9pm ice cream. Three breaths. One question. No change required.

Track how it went in the journal prompts in Chapter 9. Just note what you noticed. That's the whole week's work.

CHAPTER 6

The H.A.L.T. check, *reimagined.*

A classic tool from recovery circles — updated for women, mothers, and the particular textures of modern emotional eating.

You may have encountered H.A.L.T. before. It comes out of the addiction recovery tradition. The acronym stands for four common states that precede compulsive behavior:

- **H**ungry
- **A**ngry
- **L**onely
- **T**ired

The original practice is to ask, before acting on an urge: *Am I Hungry? Angry? Lonely? Tired?* If the answer is yes to any of them, the idea is to address that state first — feed yourself, move the anger, call someone, sleep — *before* making any other decision.

It's a good tool. It works. It has helped millions of people.

It is also — I've come to believe — **incomplete** for the specific population of women, mothers, and caregivers most likely to be reading this book.

The expanded H.A.L.T.

Over years of working with clients, I've found that four states is not quite enough. There are three more that show up regularly for women navigating the particular textures of modern life:

- **O**verwhelmed
- **B**ored (or understimulated)
- **S**ad

I call the expanded version **H.A.L.T.O.B.S.** Not a catchy acronym. But a more complete checklist.

The practice

When an urge to eat arrives — outside of a regular mealtime, or with more intensity than ordinary hunger — run through the full list in your head.

- Am I **Hungry**? (If yes, eat. That's not emotional eating. That's eating.)
- Am I **Angry**? (What about? What's unsaid?)
- Am I **Lonely**? (Who could I reach out to?)

What to do with a "yes"

Once you've named the state, you have three options. All three are valid. Pick the one that fits the moment.

OPTION 1 · ADDRESS THE STATE FIRST

Tired → 20-minute nap or early bedtime

Lonely → Text or call someone

Overwhelmed → List the top 3 tasks, do one

Bored → Walk, music, creative play

Sad → Cry, journal, call a friend

OPTION 2 · EAT WITH AWARENESS

Acknowledge: "I'm eating because I'm [state]"

Sit down. Plate the food.

Eat slowly. Taste it.

Stop when satisfied.

No shame spiral afterward — just data.

Option 3: Name the state, do nothing else. You don't have to address it. You don't have to not-eat. You can simply have said, inside yourself: *I see you. I know what this is. I'm here.* That alone has value.

THE SHIFT

H.A.L.T.O.B.S. isn't a decision tree that tells you what to do. It's an awareness tool that tells you *what's happening*. What you do with that information is yours.

CHAPTER 7

Tracing the trigger — *three questions.*

The detective work that turns a vague "I'm emotional eating again" into useful, specific information.

Awareness at the moment of eating is one thing. Awareness of the *pattern* — the shape of when and why it tends to happen — is another. This chapter is about the pattern.

Here is a truth I've come to believe: most emotional eating has a trigger that occurred 30 minutes to 24 hours *before* the eating. Not the moment itself. Earlier.

The afternoon binge that appears to come out of nowhere is usually preceded by a morning phone call that felt small but wasn't. The 9pm ice cream at the end of a normal day is often the echo of a hard 4pm meeting, not anything that happened at 9.

If you only ask "why am I eating now?" — you'll miss it. The trigger already happened.

The three questions

When you notice you've been eating emotionally — in real time, or afterward — run through these three questions. Slowly. With a journal if you have one nearby.

QUESTION 1

What was I feeling an hour before I started eating?

Not what I was feeling in the moment of the eating. Earlier. What was in the air?

QUESTION 2

What happened yesterday (or earlier today) that might still be in my body?

An emotional trigger can lag by hours. Sometimes a full day. Sometimes a whole week.

QUESTION 3

What was I needing — that wasn't food?

Rest? Company? Acknowledgment? Movement? Permission to stop working? A cry?

You'll be surprised what shows up. Patterns start to emerge. Certain people trigger you. Certain conversations. Certain weekly events. Certain moments of the day.

The pattern journal

What this reveals

The pattern journal is powerful because it moves the problem from *"I have no control"* to *"this specific thing is happening"*. And specific things have specific solutions.

A client of mine kept this log for three weeks and discovered that 80% of her emotional eating followed calls with her mother. Not a surprise, in retrospect. But she'd never named it before. Once she could see it, she had options — change the frequency of the calls, debrief with a friend after them, schedule a walk immediately afterward. The eating, by the way, decreased dramatically — not because she tried to stop it, but because she was addressing the actual source.

Another client found her pattern wasn't external at all. It was that Wednesday afternoons were her busiest workday and she wasn't eating enough at lunch. Her "emotional eating" at 8pm turned out to be, mostly, under-fueling at 1pm. The fix was a bigger lunch. The pattern resolved in a week.

You don't know what your pattern is until you look. The looking is the work.

> *The trigger happened 30 minutes ago, or yesterday, or last Thursday. The eating is the echo. Find the echo's source.*

CHAPTER 8

Emotional hunger vs. *physical hunger.*

How to tell the difference. Not to shame one. To learn to respond to each in its own language.

Most people carry a half-formed belief that "real" hunger is physical, and emotional hunger is fake, or wrong, or evidence of a broken system. That belief needs gentle correction. Both are real. Both are legitimate. They just want different things.

Here is a clear-eyed map of the differences.

PHYSICAL HUNGER

- Builds gradually
- Felt in the body (stomach, low energy)
- Satisfied by almost any food
- Stops when you're full
- No guilt after eating
- You can wait 10–20 min without crisis

EMOTIONAL HUNGER

- Comes on suddenly
- Felt in the mind (craving, mental pull)
- Wants a *specific* food — often sweet, rich, crunchy
- Doesn't stop at fullness
- Often followed by guilt or disconnection
- Feels urgent, "now"

Neither is wrong. Both are real.

I want to stress: the point of distinguishing the two is not to honor one and deny the other. Emotional hunger is a *real hunger* — it is just hunger for something other than food. Connection. Rest. Relief. Stimulation. Pleasure. Soothing.

If you respond to emotional hunger with food, you are not wrong. You are using one of the most ancient,

The practice

Next time you're about to eat — meal or not — ask a single question: *"What kind of hunger is this?"*

Physical. Emotional. Pleasure. Or some combination.

Don't change your action based on the answer. Just name it. Awareness is the whole job for now.

THE REFRAME

Physical hunger is a message that your body needs fuel.

Emotional hunger is a message that something inside you needs care.

Pleasure hunger is a message that your life would be slightly better with something delicious in it.

All three are legitimate. All three deserve a thoughtful response. None of them requires shame.

CHAPTER 9

Journal prompts *for the in-between.*

Twelve prompts for the quiet work of noticing. Do one a day. Do one a week. Whatever fits your life.

The awareness layer is built, more than anything, through writing. Not long journaling. Not therapy-style processing. Just small, specific prompts that turn a fog into a sentence.

Here are twelve. Use them in order, or shuffle them, or read through and pick the one that pulls at you. No rules. Two minutes each.

1. What am I *actually* hungry for right now?
2. What have I been postponing eating — and why?
3. When was the last time food felt peaceful?
4. What did food mean in my childhood home?
5. What is the one food I would not eat in front of someone else — and what does that tell me?
6. Which relationship in my life most reliably sends me to food afterward?
7. What did I actually need the last time I emotionally ate?
8. What's something I know I'm avoiding feeling?
9. If food were not an option today, what would I reach for instead?
10. What's one small thing I could do this week to feel more nourished (not by food)?
11. What does my body want me to know right now?
12. If a kind friend were listening to my inner dialogue about food this week, what would she gently say?

III

PART THREE

The 5-Tool *Kit.*

Five specific, practical tools for the moments when emotional eating is happening — or about to happen. Pick one. Try it this week. Add the next one when you're ready.

The *10-minute buffer.*

One of the simplest tools I teach. Does more than people expect.

The practice: when the urge to eat emotionally arrives — not meal hunger, but the *I want something specific and I want it now* urge — set a 10-minute timer before you eat.

During those 10 minutes, do literally anything else. Walk to another room. Drink a glass of water. Text a friend. Step outside. Stretch. Put on a song. Brush your teeth. Open the window.

At the end of 10 minutes, check in. Do you still want the food? If yes, eat it — with full permission, no shame. If no, move on.

THE 10-MINUTE BUFFER

Pause. Do something else for 10 minutes. Then decide.

What it does: Creates a gap between urge and action. Gives your nervous system time to regulate. Lets your prefrontal cortex come back online.

What it does not do: Ban anything. You are not promising yourself you won't eat. You are simply creating a window of awareness first.

Why 10 minutes, specifically

Most emotional urges — not all, but most — are shaped like waves. They build, they crest, they fall. The full cycle of a typical emotional-eating urge is between 8 and 20 minutes. Ten minutes lands in the middle. Often the urge has crested and begun to fall by then. Sometimes it has resolved entirely.

The buffer doesn't suppress the wave. It surfs it. You're not fighting. You're just waiting.

The two common outcomes

Outcome A: You wait 10 minutes, and the urge fades. Maybe you were stressed or bored and needed movement. Maybe you were tired and needed rest. Whatever the cause, food was not the actual need. You move on.

Outcome B: You wait 10 minutes, and you still want the food. Great — eat it. But now you're eating with awareness. You know you chose it. You know you weren't on autopilot. You'll likely eat less of it, taste more of it, and walk away without shame.

Both outcomes are wins. There is no losing outcome. That's the genius of this tool.

CHAPTER 11 · TOOL 2

The *body check.*

30 seconds of somatic awareness. Not yoga-level. Normal-person level.

The body check is a short practice — about 30 seconds — that brings you into your body before you make a food decision. It's pulled from somatic therapy but stripped of jargon.

THE BODY CHECK · 30 SECONDS

Scan. Notice. Name.

Close your eyes if safe. Take one breath.

Scan your body from the top of your head to your feet. Not analyzing. Just noticing.

Name two things: one place of tension, one place of ease.

Open your eyes. Decide what to do next.

That's it. Two sensations. One tense, one easy.

Why this works

Most emotional eating happens because you're dissociated from your body. You're in your head — looping on a thought, replaying a conversation, anticipating something. Meanwhile, your body is sending signals you can't hear. Maybe your jaw is clenched. Your shoulders are up. Your breath is shallow. Your chest feels tight.

The body check isn't about relaxing. It's about *reconnecting*. Once you've felt what's going on physically — even a little — you're in a different mental state. The urge to eat may still be there. But now you're present for the decision.

Often, clients tell me that the body check alone reveals what the emotional eating was for. "Oh — my shoulders are up to my ears. I'm tense. I was going to eat to calm down. Now that I know I'm tense, I'm going to stretch for 2 minutes first."

THE REFRAME

You cannot feed a body you've lost touch with. The body check is not a step in the eating process. It's a step in the *returning-to-yourself* process. Food decisions are much clearer from there.

When to use it

The *decision filter.*

A three-question filter that turns a foggy urge into a clear choice.

The decision filter is the most cognitive of the five tools. It gives you a fast, repeatable protocol for deciding whether to eat. It works best in moments when the answer feels genuinely unclear.

THE DECISION FILTER

Three questions, one answer.

1. **Am I hungry?** (Physical hunger, body-level. If yes, eat. Question resolved.)
2. **If I wait 20 minutes, will the urge still be here?** (If you suspect no — it's emotional, not physical. Question resolved.)
3. **Do I want this food specifically — or any food?** (A specific craving is almost always emotional. Hunger doesn't care what it is.)

Using the filter

Run the three questions in order. Stop when you have enough clarity. Most people stop after question 2.

The questions don't tell you what to do. They tell you what's happening. From there, you make the call — eat, wait, or do something else.

EXAMPLE · REAL HUNGER

Q1: Am I hungry? **Yes.**

→ Eat. No further questions needed.

EXAMPLE · EMOTIONAL

Q1: Hungry? **Not really.**

Q2: Still here in 20? **Probably not.**

Q3: This specific food? **Yes — I want chocolate.**

→ Emotional. Decide with awareness.

The filter doesn't forbid emotional eating

Eat with *awareness.*

If you've decided to eat — here's how to actually be present for it.

When you've run the other tools and decided that eating is what you want — whether the eating is for hunger, for comfort, or for pleasure — this tool is about being fully there for it.

Because mindless eating is not the same as mindful eating, even of the same food. The same bowl of ice cream, eaten on the couch in front of a screen, is a different experience than eaten at the table in silence. Both are legitimate. But only one counts as actually having the ice cream. The other counts as having something shaped like ice cream while you thought about other things.

EAT WITH AWARENESS · THE PROTOCOL

Five small shifts. That's the whole tool.

1. **Plate it.** No eating out of the bag or carton. Use a plate or bowl.
2. **Sit down.** Not in the car, not at the counter, not in bed.
3. **No screens.** Not even music with lyrics.
4. **Taste the first three bites slowly.** Really taste. Temperature, texture, flavor.
5. **Check in halfway through.** Am I satisfied? Stop if yes. Keep going if no.

What you'll notice

Usually — and this surprises people — you'll eat less of the food, and enjoy more of it. The unstoppable quality of some emotional eating episodes often comes from the fact that you're not actually present for the food. You eat, but you don't taste. You don't register fullness. So you keep eating, looking for the experience that never quite arrives.

When you eat with awareness — plated, seated, tasting — your brain registers the experience. You feel satisfied. You stop naturally.

This is not a trick to eat less. It is a practice to eat *fully*.

> *You cannot be satisfied by food you were not present for. Being present is the tool.*

The ice-cream test

Try this once. The next time you want ice cream, have it — all of it — but do it with this protocol. Plate it.

CHAPTER 14 · TOOL 5

The *aftercare script.*

The most important tool. What you say to yourself afterward.

Of the five tools in this kit, this one does the most work. Not during the eating. After.

Because the emotional-eating cycle is not completed by the eating. It is completed by the *aftermath*. The shame. The self-talk. The "I did it again." The scrolling for motivation, the promise to do better Monday, the tightening of restriction that begins the whole cycle again.

If you interrupt that aftermath, you interrupt the cycle. Even without changing a single bite of what you ate.

THE AFTERCARE SCRIPT

After any emotional eating episode, say this to yourself.

"That was information, not a verdict. I was feeling [name the state]. Food was a tool I used. It helped a little. It didn't solve it. Tomorrow I'll have another chance to meet this differently. For now — I'm okay. I am not behind. I am not broken. I am a person, practicing."

Why this matters

Shame activates the exact nervous-system state that drives emotional eating in the first place. When you punish yourself for eating, you are making the next eating episode more likely. That is not a character judgment; it is a neurological mechanism.

Compassion does the opposite. Self-compassion — not "letting yourself off the hook," but actually speaking to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend — regulates your nervous system. It keeps your executive brain online. It makes the next decision a cleaner one.

If you do only one thing from this book, let it be this: **change what you say to yourself after.**

Writing your own

The script above is mine. Yours can be different. What matters is that it has three components:

1. **Reframe:** "This was information, not a verdict."
2. **Name what was true:** "I was feeling [X]. Food was a tool I used."
3. **Reassurance:** "I am not behind. I am practicing."

Write yours on a notecard. Stick it in your kitchen drawer. Read it after. Read it when you don't think you

IV

PART FOUR

The Long *Game.*

Four short chapters on what this work looks like over years, not weeks. When emotional eating is a signal. Twenty non-food tools to build. When a therapist helps. And a letter to the version of you who'll finish this book a year from now.

CHAPTER 15

When emotional eating is *a signal, not a problem.*

A controversial reframe. Sometimes, the emotional eating is doing you a favor.

I want to say something that may not be said enough in books about this subject.

Sometimes the emotional eating is correctly diagnosing something about your life that needs to change — and the food is the message.

If every time you come home from a certain job, you emotionally eat — the eating may be pointing at the job. If every time you spend an evening with a certain person, you emotionally eat — the eating may be pointing at that relationship. If every time you sit alone after the kids are in bed, you emotionally eat — the eating may be pointing at an unnamed loneliness that isn't your kids' fault and isn't your fault but is real.

The tools in Part Three help you respond to emotional eating with skill. But sometimes, the better response is not to manage the symptom. It is to listen to what the symptom is telling you.

> *Food that reliably arrives after a specific trigger is not a bad habit. It is a smoke signal. Sometimes the right response is to find the fire.*

Ask the bigger question

After a few weeks of pattern journaling (Chapter 7), if you notice that your emotional eating is tightly correlated with something specific — a relationship, a job, a routine, a family dynamic — pause before you try to "fix" the eating.

Ask: *what is my body trying to tell me?*

Sometimes the answer is: "I need to set a boundary with [person]." Sometimes: "I need to find different work." Sometimes: "I need to be in a different marriage." Sometimes: "I need to grieve something I've never named."

These are not small answers. They may require significant life changes. The emotional eating will often resolve on its own once the underlying issue is addressed — not because you used willpower, but because the smoke signal got answered.

This is one of the hardest and most important chapters of this book. Because it says: sometimes the eating isn't the problem you need to solve. Sometimes the eating is the wise one.

CHAPTER 16

Twenty non-food alternatives *that actually work.*

Not a list of things you should do. A menu of things you could try, matched to the flavor you're meeting.

When emotional eating is the only tool in your box, everything looks like a need for food. Expanding the toolbox — slowly, gently — means finding other tools that meet the actual need.

Here are twenty. Most take under 15 minutes. Most require nothing you don't already have. Pick two or three that appeal to you. Try them. See what fits.

For stress (sympathetic overdrive)

1. Cold water on your face and inner wrists — activates the dive reflex, rapidly slows heart rate
2. Four slow breaths, exhale longer than inhale (4-in, 7-hold, 8-out)
3. A 10-minute walk outside, without a phone
4. Two minutes of shaking — literally shake out your hands, arms, whole body

For sadness

5. A 5-minute cry (set a timer; give yourself permission; it releases)
6. Call someone — not to talk about the sadness, just to hear their voice
7. A hot bath or shower, as long as you need
8. Put on a song that makes you feel seen

For loneliness

9. Text a specific person with a specific question
10. Go somewhere with other humans — coffee shop, library, park bench
11. Re-read a letter, text thread, or card from someone who loves you
12. Pet an animal (yours or a neighbor's)

For boredom / understimulation

13. A 20-minute walk in a new direction
14. A small creative project — draw, write, rearrange a shelf
15. Learn something — a 10-minute tutorial on anything
16. Cold exposure — quick cold shower, dip hands in ice water

How to use the menu

Don't try to remember all twenty. Pick three — ideally one for stress, one for sadness/loneliness, one for overwhelm — and put them on a sticky note where you can see it.

When the urge arrives, you now have three options that aren't food. You may still choose food sometimes. That's fine. But "food or food" is no longer the menu. You've expanded it.

THE SLOW SHIFT

Over six months of reaching for one of these tools a few times a week — not every time, just sometimes — you will notice food has quietly become one option among several. You didn't stop emotional eating. You grew a wider menu. That is the whole game.

CHAPTER 17

When to work *with a therapist.*

Gentle clarity on when this book is enough, and when it is not.

I wrote this book to be useful. I did not write it to replace clinical care. Here are signs that your emotional eating may benefit from professional support.

Consider working with a therapist or a non-diet registered dietitian if...

- You binge-eat regularly (defined as eating unusually large amounts in a short period, feeling out of control)
- You engage in compensatory behaviors after eating (vomiting, laxatives, excessive exercise)
- Your eating patterns are significantly disrupting your health, work, or relationships
- You experience sustained periods of not eating or severely restricted eating
- Food takes up the majority of your mental bandwidth most days
- You have a history of trauma that you suspect is connected to your eating
- You've been working on this alone for a while and it isn't shifting

Resources: National Eating Disorders Association (nationaleatingdisorders.org · helpline 1-800-931-2237). Eating Disorder Registered Dietitians (EDRD) directory. Association for Size Diversity and Health (ASDAH) for non-diet clinicians. **Psychology Today** therapist search (filter for "eating disorders" and "Health at Every Size").

CHAPTER 18

A letter to yourself, *one year from now.*

The last exercise of the book. Twenty minutes. Do it now, or do it when you're ready.

Before you close this book, I want to ask you to do one more thing. It will take maybe 20 minutes. You'll need paper and a pen.

Write a letter to yourself, dated one year from today.

In it, describe:

- What kind of relationship with food you have now
- How you spoke to yourself after the last hard day
- Which of the five tools you reach for most often
- One non-food tool you've added to your life
- One situation that used to send you to food, and no longer does
- One thing that still does — and how you've made peace with that
- How your body feels different — not smaller, necessarily. Different.
- What you'd say to the version of you who opened this book a year ago

Date the letter one year from today. Put it in a sealed envelope. Put it somewhere you'll find in a year.

> *The version of you described in that letter is not a fantasy. She is the natural outcome of what you're practicing now. She is coming.*

Two last things

One: You will have setbacks. You will have days when none of these tools work and you eat emotionally and feel the old shame. When that happens, open this book to Chapter 14. Read the aftercare script. Then close the book and go on with your day. The work continues.

Two: The woman who completes this book a year from now is already, in some sense, real. She is the sum of the small choices you will make between today and then. Every pause you take. Every journal entry. Every body check. Every time you reach for a tool instead of food. Every aftercare script you read to yourself.

She is coming. Your job is not to force her. Your job is to keep practicing. She'll arrive on her own.

A CLOSING NOTE

You were never *the enemy.*

If you take one thing from these eighteen chapters, let it be this: the part of you that reaches for food when the world feels too much — that part has been trying to take care of you. She has been doing her best, with the only tools she was ever given.

She is not broken. She does not need defeating. She needs, if anything, company. She needs other tools in the box so she isn't carrying every emotional need alone. She needs to be thanked — and, slowly, asked to step aside for the ones better suited to the job.

> *This has never been a story of defeat. It has always been a story of meeting yourself with more tenderness than you thought you deserved.*

Thank you for letting me walk with you through this.

With you,

Phyllis

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